



Hurdles beyond the field: The use of prosthetic limbs in track events in para-athletics is a fairly common sight, but for Indian athletes like Pranav Desai getting to that starting line is not easy. [INSTAGRAM @PRAANAVV_21](#)

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Blade, wheels, and grit

From racing on borrowed wheels to running on costly blades, a section of the Indian parathletes continues to face financial and **infrastructural hurdles** to pursue their passion.

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“Bachpan se hi racing ka shaunk raha hai (I have loved racing since childhood),” says Ankur Sagar. He positions

himself in a low, streamlined, kneeling stance on the seat. The structure, made of lightweight materials, has a three-wheeled design: two oversized rear wheels angled outwards for stability, and one smaller front wheel for steering. He propels himself by gripping the hand rims on the large rear wheels.

Ankur, who suffered a spinal cord injury in a car accident in 2015, has been a wheelchair racer for the past five years. While most athletics events in para sport are similar to those in which able-bodied athletes compete, disciplines such as wheelchair racing and club throw are unique and exclusive to athletes with disabilities.

Club throw requires participants to sit in a throwing frame within a marked circle and throw wooden clubs. Pranav Soorma, a silver medallist in the men’s club throw F51 event at the Paris Paralympics, shares: “A throwing frame costs around INR 50,000 depending on the specific modifications required by the parathlete.”

Before receiving government backing under the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) prior to the Asian Games in 2023, Pranav used to have his throwing frames made at local welding shops.

For clubs, even though each may cost around INR 10,000, he could not do the same. “Clubs are usually bought from overseas since the dimensions and weight requirements need to be very accurate and I haven’t found such manufacturers in India so far,” he says.

Parathletes can use the clubs provided by event organisers, but since the grip changes according to the disability of the thrower, they prefer to carry their own equipment,